may be posed and nip those in the bud by including them in the Statement itself. Concurrently, the establishment reached out to various MPs, cutting across party lines to stress that this was a matter of national security. In trying to embarrass the government of the day, the nation's image should not suffer. It would amount to 'cutting the nose to spite the face'. I have reason to believe that the point was well taken and everyone showed great maturity. The RM gave his statement to the Lok Sabha on the 14th itself and after a day's gap, to the Rajya Sabha on 16 September.[18] In his speech, the RM said, 'It is because of the great bravery of our Armed Forces in the face of harsh adverse climatic conditions that we maintained the edge. Our Armed Forces proved yet again that the territorial integrity of our country remains safe in their hands and their grit and determination to safeguard our borders is unwavering.' I had gone to 15 Corps for a visit to forward areas and when I went to meet the RM on my return, he was visibly happy and relieved that his address in Parliament had been well received.

The ongoing situation in Eastern Ladakh did not mean that other visits or activities could be put on hold. Despite the Covid restrictions, I continued to visit troops in the forward areas, especially in Northern, Central and Eastern Commands. On this particular visit, I was able to visit 109 Infantry Brigade (19 DOGRA), which visit had been cancelled earlier due to bad weather. I was to visit another unit of the same Brigade, but there had been an incident of sniping from across the LC a day earlier, so that plan was shelved. Instead, we went to 56 Rashtriya Rifles (MARATHA LI) in 53 Infantry Brigade. The jawans of the unit were happy at this change of plans and made special Maharashtrian snacks for me to have during the customary interaction over tea. During these visits to forward areas, we would alight from the ALH and move by road to

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